A W A R R I O R ' S C O D E O F P R A Y E R

A WARRIOR'S CODE OF PRAYER

Forty Days of Prayer for Men Who Work While Others Sleep

Volume I: Standing Post

Chris G. Stewart

ASHES TO ALPHA

A Warrior's Code of Prayer: Forty Days of Prayer for Men Who Work While Others Sleep
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HOW TO USE THIS BOOK

Forty entries. One a day, or one a shift, or one whenever you pick the book back up after two weeks of not picking it up. There is no streak to break. Each entry runs the same way. An anchor line from scripture. A page of plain talk about what that line has to do with the job. A drill, which is one thing you do, not one thing you feel. Then a prayer short enough to say in a truck with the engine running.

Say the prayer out loud if you can. Praying in your head is still praying, but a man who has learned to keep everything inside his head needs practice putting something outside of it.

The scripture here is the World English Bible, which is public domain. Use whatever translation you were raised on. The words are not a spell. They are a position.

ENTRY 1

Taking the Post

> *Unless Yahweh watches over the city, the watchman guards it in vain.*
> PSALM 127:1

You got up. That is the part nobody claps for.

The alarm went at 1730 for a shift that starts at 1900, and you laid there for six minutes doing the arithmetic every man in this work does. How many hours of sleep. How bad the traffic. Whether the truck has fuel. Then you put your feet on the floor, and you went, and by 1845 you were standing in a briefing room holding coffee you did not taste.

That is faith. Not the feeling of it. The act of it.

Men in this line confuse faith with certainty. They think a believing man walks out the door with his chest full of assurance and a clear picture of how the night ends. That has never been true, not for you and not for anybody who wrote a word of scripture. The psalm says the watchman guards in vain without God. It does not say the watchman gets to skip the watch. He still stands it. He still checks the gate. He still walks the fence line at 0300 in the cold with a flashlight that is dimmer than it was last month.

The verse is not permission to quit. It is a statement about who is holding the outcome. You hold the post. He holds the city.

That division of labor is the most useful thing a working man can understand about prayer. Most of what wears you down is not the work. It is carrying the outcome of the work, which was never yours to carry, and which you picked up anyway somewhere around your fourth year.

So take the post. Do the checks. Log the times. And hand the outcome across before you are standing in the parking lot at the end of it wondering why you feel forty-eight years old at thirty-four.

THE DRILL

Before you step out of the vehicle at the start of your shift, sit for ten seconds with the engine off. Say one sentence out loud: what you are responsible for tonight, and what you are not. Then get out. Ten seconds. Every shift. It is not a ritual, it is a load check.

God, I took the post. I will do the checks, walk the line, and answer the radio. The ending of this night is not mine to carry and I keep picking it up anyway. Take it back. Keep the people behind me asleep and ignorant of what it costs. Amen.

ENTRY 2

The Hours Nobody Sees

Pray to your Father who is in secret, and your Father who sees in secret will reward you openly.
MATTHEW 6:6

Nobody is going to know about tonight.

There is no report for the fence you checked that was fine. No award for the four hours you spent on a sensor hit that turned out to be cattle. The county will never learn the name of the man who sat at the intersection until 0400 so that nothing happened there. When they do a story about your agency, they will use a photo of somebody in a helicopter.

Men rot in that. Not fast. Slow, over about eight years, the way a fence post rots at the ground line while the top of it still looks fine.

Here is the thing worth knowing. The verse does not say your unseen work is fine because someday you will be recognized. It says something harder and better. It says the secret place is where the Father already is. He is not waiting at the awards ceremony. He is in the truck at 0400 with the heater rattling.

That changes the arithmetic of a boring night. If the only value of the shift is what other people find out about, then most of your career is waste with a few good stories in it. If the value of the shift is that it was done right in front of God, then the ratio flips. The seen work is the small part. The rest of it, the part nobody will ever hear about, is the actual body of your life, and it counted while it was happening.

You already believe this about other men. You know which guys on your crew do the work when the supervisor is off the schedule. You respect them more than the ones who perform. Extend yourself the same reading.

THE DRILL

Pick one thing tonight that nobody will ever check. The tire pressure. The back door of the sector building. A welfare call on a guy you have no reason to check on. Do it properly and tell no one. Not your wife, not the crew. Let it stay in the secret place where it is already counted.

Father, most of what I do disappears. I want credit and I am tired of wanting it. You were in the truck at four in the morning and I did not notice. Let the unseen hours be enough, because they are almost all of them. Amen.

ENTRY 3

Fear on Station

Be strong and courageous. Don't be afraid. Don't be dismayed, for Yahweh your God is with you wherever you go.
JOSHUA 1:9

There is a lie in this profession that you learned early and nobody ever corrected.

The lie is that the good operators do not feel fear. You watched a senior man walk toward a vehicle at night with his hands relaxed, and you decided he felt nothing, and you decided that your own heart rate at 140 was evidence of a defect. So you stopped mentioning it. By your third year you would not have used the word out loud in a briefing room.

Ask that senior man sometime. Buy him a coffee and ask him directly what his hands were doing. He will tell you.

Courage was never the absence of the thing. It is the decision that runs on top of it. God tells Joshua to be strong and courageous three separate times in the first chapter, which is not the sort of thing you say to a man who is not afraid. You do not tell a calm man to steady up. The command is spoken directly into the fear, not instead of it.

So stop auditing your feelings for evidence that you are unfit. The metric is not what your body did. The metric is what you did while your body was doing it. Did you get out. Did you make the approach. Did you give a clear direction on the radio with a voice that other men could work off of.

The second half of that verse is the load-bearing half. Wherever you go. Not wherever you go when you feel spiritual. The parking lot of a bar at 0230 counts. The bottom of a drainage with your light off counts.

THE DRILL

Next time your heart rate climbs, name it out loud in the truck, alone, in four words or less. "I am scared here." Then state the next action. "I am going to wait for the second unit." Naming it costs two seconds and it stops fear from making the decision for you.

Lord, I am afraid more than I let on, and I have spent years treating that like a flaw. You told a soldier to take courage, which means you expected him to need it. Be with me in the dark places. Steady my voice enough that the men working off it can hear the plan. Amen.

ENTRY 4

Tired Is Not Weak

> *He said to them, "You come apart into a deserted place, and rest awhile."*
> MARK 6:31

You are not lazy. You are on hour fifteen.

Somewhere in the first five years, most men in this work weld those two ideas together, and then spend the next twenty years treating fatigue as a moral failure that they have to out-discipline. So they push. They add a workout they are too smashed to recover from. They drink coffee at 2200 and tell themselves they are fine because they have always been fine.

Then something small goes wrong. They snap at a dispatcher. They forget a plate number they would normally hold for a week. They come home and cannot follow a sentence their wife is saying.

Fatigue is not weakness. It is a physical condition with physical causes, and it responds to rest and to nothing else. Not to willpower. Not to repentance. You cannot pray your way out of a sleep debt any more than you can pray away a flat tire. You change the tire.

Look at what Jesus does in that passage. His men have just come back from a working rotation. They are wound up and talking over each other, and the crowd is so thick that they cannot even eat. He does not give them a lecture on stamina. He pulls them out. The direction is to go somewhere quiet and rest, and it comes from the one man in the story who could have kept going.

If rest was a command, then treating rest as optional is not toughness. It is disobedience wearing a hard face.

There is a real distinction to hold. Sometimes you are tired and the job still requires the next four hours, and you do them. That is the work. But you do not get to call the recovery optional afterward because you are proud of how little you need.

THE DRILL

Look at your next seven days. Find one block of four hours where nothing is scheduled and nothing is owed, and write it on the calendar in ink like it is a court date. Then defend it the way you would defend a court date. If you cannot find four hours in seven days, that is the finding.

God, I am worn down and I have been calling it something else. You told tired men to go rest and you meant it as an order. Teach me the difference between the hours the job requires and the hours I am burning to prove something. Amen.

ENTRY 5

The Boredom Watch

Blessed are those servants whom the lord will find watching when he comes.

LUKE 12:37

Ninety-five percent of this job is nothing happening.

Nobody tells recruits that. They show you the vehicle pursuit and the rescue and the stack at the door. They do not show you the eleven hours of sitting on a dirt road watching a treeline that does nothing, while your legs cramp and you reread the same text message from your wife four times.

And here is the trap. The man who cannot hold a boring watch will manufacture something. He drives when he should sit. He goes looking to fill the hours. Half the bad outcomes in this profession come from a bored man deciding to generate activity rather than hold a position.

The parable is about servants waiting on a master who is late. The whole test in the story is the waiting. Anybody can look sharp in the first hour. The blessing goes to the ones still watching in the fourth watch of the night, which was the worst shift then and is the worst shift now.

Holding a boring watch well is a skill. It has parts.

Keep your eyes moving on a pattern instead of staring at one point until your vision fills it in with things that are not there. Change your posture on a schedule so your body does not quit before your attention does. Do not use the phone to kill the boredom, because the phone kills the watch along with it. And decide in advance what you are looking for, so your brain has a job rather than a vacuum.

The spiritual version is identical. Most of a man's life with God is not the dramatic night. It is a long flat stretch where nothing appears to be happening, and the temptation is to manufacture an experience or to quit the post.

THE DRILL

Tonight, work one full hour of dead time on purpose. No phone. Eyes moving on a set pattern, posture change every fifteen minutes, one specific thing you are looking for. At the end, note whether the hour was harder or easier than you expected. Most men find it easier. That is the point.

Lord, I can do the loud hour. It is the quiet one that beats me. Keep me at the post when nothing is happening and I am tempted to go make something happen. Let me be found watching. Amen.

ENTRY 6

Eyes Up

Be sober and self-controlled. Be watchful. Your adversary walks around like a roaring lion, seeking whom he may devour.
1 PETER 5:8

Complacency does not announce itself.

It arrives as competence. You have worked this area for six years. You know which houses have dogs, which road washes out, which family is always yelling and never dangerous. So your approach gets a little flatter. You stop clearing the back of the vehicle because it has been empty four hundred times. You walk up on the passenger side out of habit instead of out of decision.

That is the shape of it. Not laziness. Familiarity.

Peter writes to men getting hunted, and his instruction is to be sober and watchful. He is not telling them to be paranoid, and there is a difference that matters. Paranoia is exhausting and it degrades your judgment. Sobriety is clear-eyed. It means you are seeing the actual situation rather than the one you have gotten used to seeing.

Every experienced man has a story about the routine call. The one that was the same as two hundred others until the moment it was not. Yours is probably a specific address that you still slow down for.

Vigilance is not a personality trait you either got issued or did not. It is a discipline, and like every discipline it decays without deliberate reset. Fitness decays in three weeks. Language skills decay in months. Attention decays in about four hours, or faster if you are hungry.

So you rebuild it. On purpose. Every shift, not once a year at in-service training.

THE DRILL

Pick the call type you are most complacent on. The one you would describe as routine without thinking. Before your next one, say one sentence out loud in the truck naming the specific thing that could go wrong on this specific call. Not a general threat. A named one. Then handle it like the first time.

God, I have gotten comfortable, and comfortable is where men in my line get hurt. Keep my eyes up. Not fearful, awake. Show me the thing I have stopped seeing because I have seen it too many times. Amen.

ENTRY 7

The Radio Goes Quiet

How long, Yahweh? Will you forget me forever? How long will you hide your face from me?
PSALM 13:1

You have worked a dead net before.

You are forty minutes down a canyon with rock on both sides, you have keyed the mic twice and given your unit number twice, and there is nothing. No traffic, no acknowledgment, no tone. You check that the radio is on channel 3 and not bumped to 4. You check the battery. You hold it up over your head like every agent who has ever stood in a hole.

And you know, intellectually, that dispatch is still sitting in that room under the fluorescent lights and the agency still exists and somebody will eventually come looking. But standing in the silence at 0200 with a dead handheld, the knowing does not do much for you.

That is what a dry season with God feels like, and every honest man of faith has worked one.

Look at who wrote that psalm. David asks how long four separate times in two verses. He is not being reverent about it. He does not open with praise to soften the complaint. He says, straight out, that God has hidden his face and forgotten him, and the Holy Spirit kept that sentence in scripture for three thousand years without editing it.

Take the point. Scripture has a whole category for men who cannot feel God and say so out loud. That is not rebellion. It is in the book.

Most men in this work do the opposite. When the feeling goes, they go quiet. They stop praying because praying feels fake, and then they add guilt about not praying, and eighteen months later they are in a silence that started as one honest problem.

A dead net does not mean the agency dissolved. It means you are in a

canyon. You keep transmitting, you move a hundred meters to higher ground, and you do not act as if you have been abandoned by an organization that is still paying you.

THE DRILL

If you have gone quiet, transmit tonight. Out loud, in the truck, with the engine off. Say the actual complaint in the words you would use with a friend, not the words you would use standing in a church. "I have not felt anything in eight months and I do not know if you are there." That is a psalm. It is the same one David wrote.

Yahweh, I cannot hear you and I am tired of pretending that I can. David asked how long and you kept his question in the book, so I am asking it. I am still transmitting. I am still at the post. Amen.

ENTRY 8

End of Shift

In peace I will both lay myself down and sleep, for you alone, Yahweh, make me live in safety.
PSALM 4:8

Watch a man come off a hard shift and you can see what is going to happen at his house before he gets there.

He clears the building fast. He is already on the phone in the parking lot. He drives home with the radio off, running the night back through his head, and by the time he pulls in the driveway he has re-litigated a decision he made eleven hours ago and lost the argument twice. Then he walks in the door carrying all of it and hands the first thing that goes wrong inside the house a response sized for a felony stop.

The transition is a real piece of work and almost nobody trains it.

You know how to brief on. Times, sector, weather, the vehicle description everybody is looking for. You have never once been taught how to brief off. So the shift never actually ends. It just sits there running in the background until it drains the battery.

The psalm is a man closing a day out in the middle of trouble, not after it resolved. Read the verses before it. He has people against him. Nothing is fixed. And the last thing he does is lie down and sleep, because the safety was never a function of the trouble being over.

That is the model. You do not earn the right to put a day down by solving it.

THE DRILL

Build an end-of-shift sequence and run it the same way every time. Three parts. Name the one thing that went right. Name the one thing you would

do differently and then stop chewing it. Say where you are handing the rest. Thirty seconds in the parking lot with the engine off, before you touch the phone. Do it at the same physical spot every shift so the location starts doing half the work.

Yahweh, the shift is over and I am still running it. One thing went right tonight and I almost did not notice. I am handing you the rest of it, including the decision I keep chewing on. Let me sleep like a man who is not still on duty. Amen.

ENTRY 9

What You Carry

Come to me, all you who labor and are heavily burdened, and I will give you rest.

MATTHEW 11:28

You can tell me the weight of your vest to the ounce.

You know the plate carrier, the rifle, the radio, the med kit, the water. You have adjusted all of it over the years to sit right on a long movement. You have thrown out gear that was not worth its weight.

You have never once done that inventory on the other load.

Go ahead and try it. Not as a feeling. As a list. What are you actually carrying right now, by name. The call from March. The kid you could not get to in time. The supervisor who lied in a statement and never got touched for it. Your father. The mortgage. The physical you keep pushing back because you already know what he is going to say about the blood pressure.

Most men cannot get four items in before they stop, because writing it down makes it real in a way that carrying it does not.

The invitation in that verse is specific about who it is for. Not the peaceful. Not men who have their house in order. It says those who labor and are heavily burdened, which is the working man carrying more than he is rated for. That is the qualification. The only men excluded are the ones who will not admit the load.

Rest here is not a nap. The word carries the sense of relief from a weight, the way it feels when you finally set the pack down after nine miles and your shoulders come up an inch on their own.

You are not going to hand all of it over tonight. Hand one item.

THE DRILL

Take a sheet of paper, not your phone. Write down everything you are carrying, one line each, until you run out. Do not organize it. Do not fix anything. Circle one item, say it out loud by name, and hand that one over. Keep the paper in your truck and look at it in a week to see if the list got shorter or if you just got used to it.

Jesus, I can weigh my gear and I cannot weigh this. I have been carrying the call from this year like it is part of the kit. I am setting one thing down in front of you tonight and saying it out loud. Take it. I will bring the rest as I can. Amen.

ENTRY 10

The Call You Remember

Yahweh is near to those who have a broken heart, and saves those who have a crushed spirit.
PSALM 34:18

Every man in this work has one on top of the stack.

Not the worst one by any objective measure. The one that stuck. Sometimes it is not even the call, it is one detail from it. A shoe. A phone that kept ringing. The way somebody said a name.

You have a version of it that you tell. It is about ninety seconds long, you have told it maybe six times, and it has been sanded smooth by the telling. That version is not the problem. The problem is the other one, the one you have never said out loud, that shows up at 0300 about four times a year and runs unedited.

Men treat that as a malfunction. It is not. It is a normal human nervous system holding something it was not built to file.

The psalm says God is near to the crushed. Not impressed by them, not waiting for them to recover first. Near. That word was chosen carefully. It does not promise the memory goes away. It locates someone next to you while you have it.

Here is the part most men get wrong. They think the goal is to stop having it. So they measure their progress by whether it came back, and every return feels like failure, and the failure gets added to the pile.

Change the metric. The goal is not silence. The goal is that when it comes back you are not alone in the room with it, and that you can say it to one human being who will not flinch.

If it has moved past memory into something that is running your life, a peer support number, a chaplain, or a clinician who works with first responders is not weakness. It is the same as calling for a second unit.

THE DRILL

Say your unedited version out loud one time this week. Not the ninety-second version. To God in a parked truck, or to one man who has stood in the same places you have. Once. Then stop. You are not trying to process it tonight, you are breaking the seal on it never having been said.

God, there is a thing from that night I have never said out loud, not once, not even to you. You say you are near to the crushed. Be near for the length of one sentence while I say it. Amen.

ENTRY 11

Anger in the Truck

> *Be angry, and don't sin. Don't let the sun go down on your wrath.*
> EPHESIANS 4:26

You were fine until the guy at the light took four seconds to move.

Then you were not fine, and the volume of what came out of you in a sealed vehicle was out of proportion to a green light by a factor of about fifty. You knew it while it was happening. You did it anyway.

Anger like that is almost never about the thing in front of it. It is pressure looking for a low-resistance path, and a stranger who cannot answer back is the lowest resistance path available.

Notice what the verse does not say. It does not say anger is a sin. It says be angry and do not sin, which means Paul assumed his readers would be angry and was giving them guidance on the handling of it. Anger is information. It is your system reporting that something is wrong. A man who cannot get angry at the right things is not holy, he is checked out.

The instruction is on the timeline. Do not let the sun go down on it. Deal with it inside one cycle, before it becomes structure.

That is a maintenance schedule. Same as anything else on the truck. Low-level anger that does not get addressed within a day becomes a week, then it becomes how your family describes you to other people.

The work here is finding the actual source. It is almost never the light. It is the statement your supervisor signed. It is the eleventh time your day off got taken. It is something from 2019 you never named. Until you name the real one, every stranger with a slow reaction time will keep getting the bill.

THE DRILL

Next time it hits, do not suppress it and do not ride it. Ask one question out loud: what is this actually about. Say the first answer even if it sounds stupid. Then before you sleep, take one concrete action on the real source. Send the email. Ask for the meeting. Tell one person. One cycle.

God, I took something out on a stranger today and he had no idea he was standing in for somebody else. Show me what this is really about. Give me the spine to go at the real thing before I sleep instead of dumping it on whoever is nearest. Amen.

ENTRY 12

The Guilt You Kept

If we confess our sins, he is faithful and righteous to forgive us, and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness.
1 JOHN 1:9

You have made decisions in four seconds that other people have spent months reviewing.

That asymmetry is the specific cruelty of this work. A board sits in a room with coffee and a whiteboard and pulls apart something you did with partial information, at night, while your heart rate was at 160 and somebody was screaming. Then you spend the next three years running your own review, except your review never adjourns and never issues a finding.

There are two different things in that pile and you have to separate them, because they need opposite treatment.

The first is regret. You did the best available thing with what you had and the outcome was still bad. That is not sin and confession will not touch it, because there is nothing to forgive. What that needs is a verdict from somebody qualified to give one, and the willingness to accept it.

The second is actual guilt. You did something wrong. You know exactly what it was. You have never said it plainly to anybody, and you have built about nine years of justification around it.

For the second one, the verse is precise and it is a legal statement. Confess, and he is faithful and righteous to forgive. Not likely to. Not if you feel bad enough for long enough. Faithful and righteous, which means that a confessed sin being held against you would be a violation of his own character.

Most men are carrying the first kind and treating it as the second, or carrying the second and calling it the first. Do the sort first. The treatment

is different.

THE DRILL

Write the incident down in one paragraph, factually, the way you would write a statement. Then write two headers under it: what I did wrong, and what was outside my control. Put every sentence under one of them. The second list gets handed off. The first list gets confessed out loud, tonight, by name.

Father, I have been running the same review for years and it never closes. Here is the part that was actually mine, said plainly and without the arguments I have been building around it. You called yourself faithful and righteous about this. I am taking you at your word and closing the file. Amen.

ENTRY 13

Men Who Did Not Make It

Jesus wept.
JOHN 11:35

Two words. The shortest verse in the book, and it is the one that matters most to men in this line.

He is standing outside the tomb of a friend. He knows, with complete certainty, that in about four minutes Lazarus is going to walk out of it under his own power. The outcome is not in question. He is not grieving a permanent loss and he is not uninformed about what happens next.

He weeps anyway.

Put that against how you were trained. You were taught, mostly by watching, that grief in this work is something you do briefly, in private, and then set aside because the next call is coming. You have seen men go straight from a scene to a lunch order and you filed that as strength.

It is not strength. It is a skill for staying functional during a shift, which is a real and necessary skill, and it is not the same thing as processing a loss. The problem is that nobody ever taught the second half. So the pause button gets pressed and never released, and by year twelve there are eleven unreleased pauses stacked in a man.

You have names. The one from the academy who did not make twenty-five. The guy from your first station. The one who got through the whole career and then did it himself in his garage four months after retirement, and everybody said they had no idea, and some of you did have an idea and did not call.

Grief has to come out somewhere. It comes out as grief, or it comes out as anger, or it comes out as a man drinking alone at 1400 on a Tuesday.

If you are the one whose name is on somebody else's list right now, call 988 or your peer support line tonight. Not tomorrow.

THE DRILL

Say one name out loud. Add one full sentence about what he was actually like, not how he died. Then say what you are still angry about, because with most of these there is anger under the grief and it has never been allowed on the net.

Jesus, you cried at a funeral you were about to cancel, so you are not going to tell me to hold it together. I am saying his name. I am still angry about it. Sit with me here for a minute. Amen.

ENTRY 14

The Body Keeps Time

> *I will give thanks to you, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made.*
> PSALM 139:14

Your body has been keeping a log this whole time and has never once asked your permission.

The knee that tells you about the weather. The shoulder you can no longer sleep on. Blood pressure that was 118 over 70 at the academy and has drifted every year since without one dramatic event to blame. The way you wake at 0230 on your days off because your system has decided that is a working hour.

Night shift is not a scheduling preference. It is a physiological event. Rotating men through nights and days moves the whole endocrine system around, and your body files a report on that in the form of weight, sleep, mood, and a heart that works harder than it should for a man your age.

Men in this profession treat the body like a vehicle in the fleet. Run it hard, defer the maintenance, and assume someone will hand you a replacement. Nobody is handing you a replacement.

The psalm says fearfully and wonderfully made, and men read that as a compliment. It is closer to a specification. This thing was designed with tolerances, and it reports honestly when it is outside them. That report is not disloyalty and it is not age. It is the instrument working.

The spiritual mistake is treating the body as the enemy of discipline, something to be overridden. Scripture never treats it that way. The body is the place you actually live and the thing every bit of your work gets done through.

You would not run a truck for six years with the oil light on and call that toughness.

THE DRILL

Book the physical you have been deferring. Today, before this book closes, on the phone or online, with a date on it. Then write down the three things your body has been reporting for over a year that you have been explaining away, and bring that paper to the appointment so you do not perform wellness in the room.

God, you built this thing and I have been running it like it is disposable. The knee, the sleep, the number on the cuff. I have been calling the warnings age. Give me the humility to book the appointment and say the true numbers out loud to somebody qualified. Amen.

ENTRY 15

Drinking It Down

Wine is a mocker and beer is a brawler. Whoever is led astray by them is not wise.

PROVERBS 20:1

Nobody starts out drinking to stop feeling. It starts as a crew going out after a rough one, which is a good thing and does real work for men.

The drift is slow. The crew stops going and you keep going. Then it moves to the garage. Then it moves to a number you would not say out loud to your doctor. Then, somewhere in there, it stops being a social thing and becomes a tool. It is the only thing that reliably shuts the noise off after a shift, and it works every single time, which is exactly what makes it dangerous.

The proverb gives you the shape of it. A mocker and a brawler. It does not say the wine is evil. It says it deceives. It tells you it is helping while it is taking things, and the things it takes are the ones you would have said were untouchable. Sleep quality first. Then the training you stopped doing. Then patience with your kids. Then mornings.

Here is the honest measurement, the one that cuts through the arguments you have already prepared. Not how much. Whether you can stop. Take two weeks with none. If that sentence produced an immediate reason why these next two weeks are a bad window, you have your answer and you did not need the two weeks.

This is not a lecture about being a teetotaler. It is a question about who is driving.

If you cannot stop, that is not a character verdict. It is a medical situation and it has treatment. Talk to your doctor, a peer support program, or a counselor who works with people in this line of work. Stopping some of it abruptly can be genuinely dangerous, which is a reason to get help

rather than a reason to keep going.

THE DRILL

Fourteen days, none. Write the start date on paper. Tell one man who will actually ask you about it on day seven. Track what changes in sleep and in your mornings. If you cannot make it to day three, that is not a failure, that is the diagnostic result, and it is information you needed.

God, it works, and that is the problem. It shuts everything off and it has been taking a payment out of me for years. I am setting it down for fourteen days and I need you for the nights when it is the only thing that has ever reliably worked. Amen.

ENTRY 16

Asking for Help

Bear one another's burdens, and so fulfill the law of Christ.
GALATIANS 6:2

You will call for a second unit without a second thought.

You have requested air support, asked for a translator, ordered a medevac, and called a colleague at 0200 about a warrant question. You do all of that instantly, without ego, because the mission requires it and because you are competent enough to know what you cannot do alone.

Then you get home and you will not tell your wife you are struggling.

That is not consistency. That is a category error. You treat operational help as tactical and personal help as confession, and only one of them feels like an admission of failure. Both are the same act. Both are a man reporting an accurate picture of his capability against the task.

Paul writes to carry each other's loads, and he calls that the fulfillment of Christ's law, which is heavy language for a practical instruction. Note the direction he assumes. It runs both ways. A man who only ever carries for others and never lets anybody carry for him is not obeying that verse. He is violating half of it and taking credit for the other half.

There is a man on your crew right now who would take your call and never mention it again. You know exactly which one. You have been not calling him for about two years.

The reason is not pride, usually. It is arithmetic. You have decided your problem would cost more to hand over than to carry. That arithmetic is almost always wrong, and it is the same arithmetic that gets men to walk into a building alone.

If the load has moved past hard into dangerous, call 988 in the United States, or your agency peer support line. Tonight, not after this rotation.

THE DRILL

Text one man today. Not a status update. One true sentence about where you actually are, with no joke attached to soften it. "I am not doing well and I have not said that to anybody." Send it before you overthink the wording. Then answer the phone when it rings.

Lord, I will call for anything the mission needs and nothing that I need. You made carrying each other a law and I have been obeying half of it for years. Give me the nerve to send one honest sentence to one man tonight. Amen.

ENTRY 17

Walking In the Door

> *As for me and my house, we will serve Yahweh.*
> JOSHUA 24:15

The first ninety seconds decide the next twelve hours.

You know this. You have watched it go both ways in your own kitchen. There is a version where you come in, set the bag down, find whoever is awake, and put a hand on a shoulder before you say a word. And there is a version where you come in scanning, see the dishes, and open with a question that is technically about dishes.

Same man, same house, same day. Different first ninety seconds, completely different evening.

The problem is that you are still running the posture the job requires. On shift you scan for what is wrong, because that is the entire skill. Find the anomaly. Notice the thing out of place. You have spent years building that until it runs without being asked for.

Then you carry it through your own front door and point it at people who are not a threat and are not an assignment.

Joshua makes his declaration at the end of a long career of hard movement. He is old. He has done the work. And the thing he stakes out is not a battlefield, it is a household. He names his house as the unit he is responsible for and the thing he will be accountable for.

You are the supervisor of that unit. Nobody else is going to set the tone of it, and the tone gets set in the doorway.

This is not about being soft when you get home. It is about switching from a scanning posture to a presence posture, which is a different skill and one you have never practiced deliberately once.

THE DRILL

Build a threshold drill and run it every day for two weeks. Stop at the door before you open it. Say one sentence in your head about who is on the other side and what they need from you. Then go in and find a person before you find a problem. Hand on a shoulder, name said out loud. The dishes will still be there in ten minutes.

God, I bring the wrong posture through my own door and my family has learned to read it before I say anything. Let me find a person before I find a problem tonight. This house is the unit I answer for. Amen.

ENTRY 18

Your Wife Is Not the Enemy

Husbands, love your wives, even as Christ also loved the assembly and gave himself up for it.
EPHESIANS 5:25

She said you have been distant and you heard it as an accusation.

So you defended. You listed the hours, the overtime, the fact that you have not had a full weekend since June, and every item on that list was true. And she was not making a case against you in the first place. She was reporting a condition, and you answered a report with a defense, which told her that raising it costs something.

Do that about forty times and she stops raising it. That silence is not peace. That is a person who has learned the topic is closed.

Here is the mechanism nobody names. You spend your working hours in an adversarial posture. Somebody is lying to you, somebody is testing you, somebody wants something from you and is willing to work an angle to get it. You get good at detecting that. You have to.

Then she says one sentence with an edge in it and the detection system fires on the closest human being.

Paul does not tell husbands to lead, provide, or hold the line, all of which you would find easier. He tells them to love the way Christ loved the church, and then defines it as giving himself up. The model is a man laying something down, not a man holding something.

For you, what gets laid down is the posture. The readiness to be right. The eleven-item list of everything you did this month that proves you are not the problem.

She is not the enemy. She is the one person in your life who has no tactical reason to lie to you about how you are doing, which makes her report the most reliable intelligence you have access to.

THE DRILL

Next time she raises something, say nothing for five seconds and then ask one question instead of giving one answer. "How long has it been like that?" Then let her talk without correcting a single fact, even the ones that are wrong. You are not conceding the case. You are collecting the report.

God, I treat her like a threat and she has never once been one. Take the readiness to defend out of my hands before she starts talking tonight. Let me hear the report without answering it. Amen.

ENTRY 19

The Kid Who Waited Up

You shall teach them diligently to your children, and shall talk of them when you sit in your house, and when you walk by the way.
DEUTERONOMY 6:7

He waited up again and you told him to go to bed.

You were right. It was 2340, he has school, and he has done this four nights this week. You handled it correctly and you were tired and you were not wrong.

He is also nine, and what he has figured out is that the only window where he gets you alone is the one where you come in the door. So he keeps engineering it, and getting sent to bed, and engineering it again, because a kid will take negative contact over no contact every time.

Presence is not measured in intent. It is measured in minutes given, which is a brutal metric and the only honest one. You intend to be a present father. You would put your body between that boy and anything. That is real and it is not the same as time, and children cannot read intent. They can only read attendance.

Look at what Moses describes. Sitting in the house. Walking by the way. Lying down and rising up. It is not a program. There is no curriculum and no scheduled block. It is the ordinary hours of a normal day used deliberately, which means the transfer of everything you believe happens in the slots you keep thinking of as leftover time.

You do not have a lot of those slots. That is a real constraint and it is not going away while you are working this schedule. So the slots you do have have to be actually given, not given while looking at a phone.

Fifteen honest minutes beats a Saturday you spent physically present and mentally back on the Thursday incident.

THE DRILL

Pick one recurring slot that already exists. The drive to practice. The ten minutes before he sleeps on your days off. Breakfast on the two mornings you are home. Name it, defend it, and put the phone in another room during it. One slot, held for a month, beats a new tradition you will not sustain past three weeks.

Father, my son keeps making chances to be near me and I keep sending him to bed for good reasons. Show me the slot I already have. Give me the discipline to put the phone down inside it. Amen.

ENTRY 20

Teaching a Boy to Stand

Train up a child in the way he should go, and when he is old he will not depart from it.
PROVERBS 22:6

He is not listening to your advice. He is watching your Tuesday.

Every father in this profession has a speech he has given about hard work, or about telling the truth, or about finishing what you start. Most of us gave that speech in the truck with the boy strapped in behind us, and it was a good speech, and it moved almost nothing.

What moves him is watching you come home smoked after fourteen hours and still stand up to do the thing you said you would do. What moves him is hearing you on the phone with somebody who is being unreasonable, and hearing you stay level. What moves him is watching how you talk about a supervisor you do not respect when you think only family is in the room.

He is running a continuous observation on you and filing it under what a man does. Not what a man says. What a man does when he is tired, angry, or caught being wrong.

That proverb has been misread as a guarantee by about four generations of anxious parents, and used as a stick by others. Read it as what it is, a proverb about the deep grain of training. The word carries the sense of dedicating something toward its direction. What you install early sets a direction, and direction is durable even when behavior is not.

Which means the training is happening right now whether or not you designed it. You are installing something this week. The question is only whether you chose it.

The most transferable thing you own is not your job. It is the ability to keep a commitment when nothing in your body wants to.

THE DRILL

Pick one thing you want him to be able to do at thirty. Then do it visibly, in front of him, this week, and name it out loud once while you are doing it. Not a lecture. One sentence. "I am going because I said I would, not because I want to." Then let him watch the rest.

God, he is copying me and not listening to me, and some of what he is copying I did not choose. Make my Tuesday worth imitating. Let him see me keep one thing this week that I did not feel like keeping. Amen.

ENTRY 21

What You Say at the Table

Let your speech always be with grace, seasoned with salt, that you may know how you ought to answer each one.
COLOSSIANS 4:6

Your family is building their picture of the world out of what gets said at your table.

Think about what actually gets said there. For most men in this work it is a short list. Who was an idiot today. What the agency did wrong. A story with the hard parts sanded off. Something about money. Then silence and phones.

That is not a moral failure. It is what comes out when a man arrives at a table with no plan and eleven hours of accumulated irritation.

But it compounds. A kid who hears four years of dinner conversation learns, without anyone teaching it, that people are mostly stupid, institutions are mostly corrupt, and adults mostly complain. He will not be able to tell you where he learned it. He will just believe it at nineteen.

Paul says speech seasoned with salt. Salt is not decoration. It preserves, and it makes a thing taste like itself. Speech seasoned with salt is speech with something actually in it. It is not the same as being positive, and it is definitely not the same as being careful.

You are allowed to say hard things at your table. You should. The job is real and pretending otherwise teaches children that adults lie about their lives. The question is whether anything else ever gets said.

You already know how to do this professionally. You brief. You give a crew the situation and then you give them a next action, because you know that situation without action produces paralysis. Your family gets the situation with no next action about four nights a week.

THE DRILL

Bring one thing to the table tomorrow. Not a lesson. One true item that is not a complaint. Something you saw, something somebody did right, a question you actually want the answer to. Ask it before anybody sits down and let it run. One item, every meal you are home for, for two weeks.

Lord, my table runs on complaint and my kids are learning the world from it. Give me one true thing to bring home tomorrow that is not a grievance. Let what I say at that table preserve something instead of souring it. Amen.

ENTRY 22

The Days You Miss

So teach us to count our days, that we may gain a heart of wisdom.
PSALM 90:12

You are going to miss the game.

Not because you are a bad father. Because the schedule came out in August and the game is on a Saturday in your rotation, and the man who would have covered it is already carrying two shifts for somebody else. That is the job. It was the job when you took it.

There are two different errors men make here and they look like opposites.

The first is pretending it does not cost anything. You get good at the line. "That is the job, buddy." Delivered flat, so nobody in the house is allowed to be sad about it out loud, because you are not allowing it in yourself. The cost is real and the family knows it is real, and a father who will not name it teaches everybody to lie about how they feel.

The second error is drowning in it. The man who misses one birthday and then carries it like a felony for two years, apologizing so much that the child ends up managing the father's guilt. Kids can handle a father who is gone. They have a much harder time handling a father who needs them to say it is okay.

The psalm asks God to teach the counting of days, and the reason given is wisdom, not grief. Counting is what makes you choose. A man with unlimited days does not have to prioritize anything. A man who has counted knows that this fall has eleven Saturdays in it and he is home for four.

So handle the miss like an operator. Name it, mark it, and put something real on the other side of it.

THE DRILL

Get the calendar out with your wife and count. How many of his games are you actually home for this season. Say the number out loud. Then pick one that you will not miss for anything short of a callout, and tell the kid which one it is, by date, so that he is waiting for a specific thing rather than hoping in general.

God, I am going to miss it and I cannot fix the schedule. Keep me from pretending it does not cost anything and from making my son carry my guilt about it. Teach me to count what I have got so I spend it on purpose. Amen.

ENTRY 23

Keeping One Promise

> *Let your "Yes" be "Yes" and your "No" be "No."*
> MATTHEW 5:37

The damage is not done by the big broken promise. It is done by the small ones, at volume.

You said you would look at the bike. You said you would call your mother back. You said Saturday. None of those were lies when you said them. Every one of them was a real intention issued by a tired man who wanted to give somebody something in the moment and had not looked at the week.

Over a couple of years, the people in your house build a model of you. In that model, what you say has a reliability rating, and it is lower than you think. They stop planning around your yes. They wait to see.

That is a far worse injury than a missed weekend, and it is entirely inside your control, which the schedule is not.

Christ's instruction is aimed at men who over-swore. In that culture people stacked oaths to make a promise sound more binding, and he says cut all of it and let a plain yes carry the full weight. That only works if your yes is expensive. If you hand out yes freely because it is the fastest way to end a conversation, you have made your own word cheap and then wondered why nobody spends it.

The fix is not to promise more carefully in general. It is to reduce volume and raise reliability. One yes that is real beats four that are hopeful.

And when you break one, which you will, the repair is specific. Name it without excuses, say what you are doing instead, and do that thing. Not "sorry, work got crazy." That is a weather report, not a repair.

THE DRILL

For one week, say no or say a specific time. Nothing in between. "I cannot" is a complete answer. "Saturday at 10" is a complete answer. "I will try to get to it" is now off the table. Count how many times you almost used the old phrase. That count is the size of the problem.

God, my word has gotten cheap in my own house and I did it one small yes at a time. Teach me to say no plainly and to make my yes expensive. Let me keep the next one exactly as I said it. Amen.

ENTRY 24

Rest That Is Not Collapse

> *You shall labor six days, and do all your work.*
> EXODUS 20:9

Most men in this line do not rest. They collapse, recover just enough to be functional, and call that a day off.

You know the shape of it. You come off a stretch, you sleep until 1100, you are useless until about 1500, and then you burn what is left on errands that piled up. Monday you go back in having been off duty for two days and rested for none of them.

Collapse is what happens to the leftover hours. Rest is a thing you schedule and defend.

Notice which half of the commandment gets quoted. Everybody knows the sabbath half. Almost nobody quotes the first half, which is an instruction to work six days and do all your work. The command has two edges. Do the work, all of it, and then genuinely stop. Men in this profession are excellent at the first edge and treat the second as a suggestion for people with easier jobs.

Here is why it is not soft. An unrested man makes worse decisions and cannot tell that he is making them. That is the specific danger of fatigue, that the instrument measuring your judgment is the thing that is degraded. You are not the exception. Nobody who has ever said they were the exception was the exception.

Rest also has to have content. A day off spent on the phone reading about things that make you angry is not rest, it is a different kind of work with no pay. Real rest for most men is physical, outdoors, with other people, and away from the thing that pays them.

Your schedule is genuinely hard. That is a reason to plan rest deliberately, not a reason to skip it.

THE DRILL

Take the next fourteen days and find one block of six hours that you will protect like a court date. Put one thing in it that is not a chore and not a screen. Tell one person it is happening so it costs something to cancel. Six hours, planned, defended. Not the leftovers.

God, I collapse and I call it rest and then I wonder why nothing refills. You commanded the work and then commanded the stop, and I have been treating half of that as optional. Show me the six hours and give me the spine to defend them. Amen.

ENTRY 25

The New Guy

Let no man despise your youth, but be an example to those who believe, in word, in your way of life, in love, in faith.
1 TIMOTHY 4:12

How the newest man gets treated is the actual standard. Everything else is a poster.

You can read a station in twenty minutes by watching what happens to the guy with eleven months on. Does anybody explain the reason behind a procedure, or does he just get told. Does he get corrected in front of people, or off to the side. Does anybody eat lunch with him.

The written standards do not matter much next to that. The new guy is learning the real culture, and he is learning it fast, because a man that new is absorbing everything and cannot yet tell the difference between what is doctrine and what is one senior guy's bad habit.

Five years from now he will do it the way he saw it done in month eleven. That is the whole transmission mechanism. Not the academy. Not the policy manual.

Paul writes to a young leader who is getting dismissed because of his age, and the instruction is not to demand respect. It is to be the example, in word and in way of life, and let that settle the question. That cuts both directions. If you are the young man, the answer is your conduct, not your argument. If you are the senior man, then his conduct is downstream of yours whether or not you signed up for that.

There is a specific failure worth naming. The senior guy who is technically excellent and quietly cruel. He is competent, so nobody corrects him, and he teaches an entire generation that competence buys you the right to treat people badly.

Do not be him. And when you are in the room with him and he starts

on the new guy, the silence of every other senior man is the thing the new guy actually remembers.

THE DRILL

Find the newest man on your crew this week. Give him one piece of the reasoning behind something he has only been told to do. Not the rule. The reason, and the story of what happened to somebody when it was not followed. Ten minutes. That is how doctrine gets transferred.

God, the new guy is learning what this work is from watching me, and some of what he is learning I would not defend out loud. Make me worth copying. Give me the nerve to say something the next time the room goes quiet while somebody works him over. Amen.

ENTRY 26

Leading Tired Men

Those who wait for Yahweh will renew their strength. They will run and not be weary. They will walk and not faint.
ISAIAH 40:31

On hour fourteen, leadership is almost entirely about lowering the noise.

Early in a long operation you can lead with energy. Men will follow intensity for about six hours. After that, intensity from the supervisor reads as panic, and tired men hearing panic start making their own plans, and now you have four independent plans running on one net.

What tired men need is different and it is unglamorous. They need the next task, stated in one sentence. They need to know how long. They need somebody to tell them when to eat and to mean it. And they need to see that the man in charge is not deteriorating faster than they are.

That is it. That is the whole toolkit at hour fourteen.

Read the verse in order, because the order is the point. Mount up with wings. Run and not be weary. Walk and not faint. It descends from soaring to running to walking, which is not a downgrade, it is the actual arc of a long operation. The last and hardest promise is the walking one. Anybody can be inspired. Continuing to walk when there is nothing left is the thing that requires supplied strength.

Most leadership writing sells you the eagle. The job is almost entirely the walk.

So when you are running men late into something, stop trying to generate a moment. Bring the noise down. Shorten the sentences. Give the next thing, the duration, and the food plan. Then be visibly steady, because twenty tired men are reading your face for information about how bad this is.

THE DRILL

Next time you are past hour twelve with men under you, do three things in the first sixty seconds of contact. Name the next task in one sentence. Give a time. Tell them the next food or water point. Then stop talking. Watch what it does to the net.

God, I am leading men who are past empty and I am close behind them. Take the noise out of my voice. Give me the next sentence, short and clear. Let them see somebody steady when they look at me. Amen.

ENTRY 27

The Supervisor You Hate

> *If it is possible, as much as it is up to you, be at peace with all men.*
> ROMANS 12:18

You are going to work for him for at least another year.

That is the fact underneath all of this. You cannot fire him, the complaint went nowhere, and the rotation that would move one of you is not on the schedule. Every fantasy you have run about this being resolved is not a plan.

So the only live question is what kind of man you are while you work for him.

There is a cost you may not have counted. Contempt is metabolically expensive. You carry it home. You rehearse conversations in the shower. You give a tenth of your mental bandwidth to a man you do not respect, which is the largest raise he will ever get out of you.

Paul builds two escape hatches into that verse and he builds them on purpose. If it is possible. As much as it is up to you. He is not commanding a result, because the result is not in your control. He is limiting the scope of your responsibility to the part you actually own, which is your conduct.

That is a relief if you take it correctly. You are not obligated to make him reasonable. You are not obligated to feel warm. You are obligated for your half.

Your half looks specific. You do not talk about him to the new guys, because that is where his authority actually gets destroyed and it takes the whole chain with it. You put things in writing, professionally, so that reality has a record. You do your work at a standard that makes his opinion of it irrelevant. And when there is a real integrity issue rather than a personality issue, you take it up the correct channel, once, properly, and

let it go where it goes.

THE DRILL

For one week, do not mention him to anyone junior to you. Not once. Not a joke, not an eye roll. Notice how many times you were about to. That count tells you how much of your day he is renting for free.

God, I hate working for this man and I have let him rent space in my head for two years. I am responsible for my half. Keep my mouth shut in front of the young guys and my work clean enough that his opinion does not matter. Amen.

ENTRY 28

Loyalty With a Spine

The wounds of a friend are faithful, although the kisses of an enemy are profuse.
PROVERBS 27:6

The hardest thing you will ever do on a crew is tell a friend he is wrong.

Not a stranger. Not a subordinate you can correct through the chain. A man you have worked beside for nine years, whose kids know your kids, who came to your father's funeral. And he is drinking too much, or he has gotten heavy-handed on contacts, or he has started cutting corners on paperwork in a way that is going to end him.

Everybody on the crew can see it. Nobody has said anything, because saying something feels like betrayal.

That is the counterfeit. Loyalty that cannot say a hard thing is not loyalty. It is conflict avoidance wearing a friendship, and it is how good men get lost while eight guys who love them watch it happen and say nothing until the investigation.

The proverb sets it up as a contrast between two kinds of touch. A friend wounds. An enemy is generous with the pleasant stuff. The measure of which one you are dealing with is not how it feels in the moment, it is whether he will tell you something that costs him.

There is a right way to do it and most men get the delivery wrong, which is why they avoid it. Not in front of the crew. Not stacked with four other complaints you have saved up. Not as a joke with a real point in it, which is the coward's version and everybody sees through it.

One man, one time, direct, specific, with the door left open. "I am saying this because I want you to be here in five years."

And then you stay. The wound is only faithful if you are still standing there afterward.

THE DRILL

You already know whose name this entry is about. Pick the time and place this week. One specific behavior, not a character summary. Say what you see, say why you are saying it, and say what you are willing to do to help. Then stay in the room.

God, I have watched a friend slide for a year and called my silence loyalty. Give me the words and the timing. Let me wound him faithfully and then stay standing there when he is angry about it. Amen.

ENTRY 29

Getting Passed Over

Neither from the east, nor from the west, nor from the south, comes exaltation. But God is the judge. He puts down one and lifts up another.
PSALM 75:6

The list came out and your name was not on it.

You already know who did make it and you already have a theory about why. Some of that theory is accurate. Boards are run by people, people have preferences, and sometimes the selection is genuinely about who was visible to the right man at the right time rather than who can do the work.

Sit with the accurate part for a second, because pretending the system is perfectly fair is its own kind of weakness. Then get to the part that matters, which is what this does to you over the next six months.

There are two ways men handle this and only one of them survives.

The first is to take the list as a verdict. He internalizes it. He decides that the organization has made an assessment of his worth and that the assessment is correct, and something goes out of the way he works. You have watched this happen to somebody. He is still there, doing the minimum, twelve years later.

The second is to take the list as data about a process. It tells you about this board, in this cycle, under these criteria. It does not tell you what you are worth, because a promotion board has no instrument that measures that.

The psalm makes the same distinction with more authority behind it. Exaltation does not come from any direction on the compass. It is not distributed by geography or by who you know in a region. God is the judge. That is either a cold statement or a liberating one depending on whether you actually wanted the list to be the final word on you.

THE DRILL

Write down two lists. What this board actually told you about how you are seen, and what you can change before the next cycle. Keep it factual. Then write one sentence about what you are worth that does not reference a rank, and read that one out loud. That sentence is the one you will need in about four months when this comes back around.

God, my name was not on it and part of me took that as the truth about me. You are the judge and a board is not. Show me what is real in the feedback and let me throw out the verdict I handed myself. Amen.

ENTRY 30

Keeping Your Word In Writing

Lying lips are an abomination to Yahweh, but those who do the truth are his delight.
PROVERBS 12:22

Your integrity in this profession will mostly be decided in paperwork.

Not in a dramatic moment. In a report you wrote at 0430 on your sixth day, when you were smoked and the easy version was two sentences shorter than the accurate one. In a training log where you rounded four hours to eight. In a statement where you left out the part that makes you look slow.

Nobody will ever catch most of it. That is exactly the point.

Documents in this work outlive the men who write them. A report you filed in 2019 can surface in a proceeding in 2031, read out loud by somebody who does not know you, in a room where you do not get to explain the context. What is on the page is what happened, as far as that room is concerned.

The proverb splits people by what they do rather than by what they feel about honesty. Doing the truth. It is an activity. It is the man who goes back and corrects a document that nobody flagged, at 0500, when he could have gone home.

There is a second-order effect that men underestimate. The habit of small written inaccuracy erodes your own memory of events. Write it sloppy enough times and you no longer have an accurate record of your own career. You start believing your own smoothed version, and then you cannot learn from the real one.

This is also how you protect other people. Your log is the only thing that can defend the new guy in three years when somebody comes after him for something he did right.

THE DRILL

Pull up the last report you wrote. Read it as if you were a hostile attorney with time and no relationship to you. Find one sentence that is technically true and functionally misleading, and fix it. If there is nothing to fix, you have a baseline. If there is something, you now know your actual standard rather than your intended one.

Yahweh, my name is on documents I wrote tired and I did not always tell the whole shape of it. Make me a man who does the truth in writing when nobody will ever check. Give me the stomach to go back and correct the one I am thinking about. Amen.

ENTRY 31

When You Were Wrong

Confess your sins to one another and pray for one another, that you may be healed.
JAMES 5:16

A clean admission costs less than every version of covering it. Every time. Without exception.

You know this from the outside. You have watched a man take a small mistake and turn it into a career-ending problem purely through the handling. The original error was survivable. The four months of managing it were not.

You do not know it from the inside, because from the inside the covering always feels cheaper in the moment. It is a five-minute decision made under pressure, and the bill for it arrives in installments over years.

Here is what the covering actually costs. You have to remember the version you gave. You have to avoid a specific person, or a specific topic, indefinitely. You carry a low-grade readiness for it to surface. And every man who suspects the truth has a piece of leverage on you that he did not ask for and may never use, which does not stop it from being leverage.

James does not say confess to God, which is the version most men prefer because it is private and produces no social cost. He says to one another. Out loud, to a person, which is the part that actually breaks the hold, because what a hidden thing runs on is being hidden.

And then he attaches a purpose. So that you may be healed. Not so that you can be punished, or so that the record can be corrected, though sometimes the record does need correcting. The stated goal is that the man gets well.

You have one you have never said. You knew which one before you finished this paragraph.

THE DRILL

Say it to one human being this week. Pick a man who has no ability to use it against you and no need to. Say it plainly, without the surrounding argument that makes it sound smaller. You do not have to fix anything in the same conversation. Get it out of the dark first, because in the dark it keeps growing and you cannot see how big it actually is.

God, I have been managing something for a long time and the managing costs more than the thing ever did. I am going to say it out loud to a man this week. Keep me from softening it while it is coming out of my mouth. Amen.

ENTRY 32

The Man You Trained

The things which you have heard from me, commit to faithful men who will be able to teach others also.
2 TIMOTHY 2:2

Nothing you personally accomplish in this career will outlast the men you taught.

Count it honestly. Your case numbers get archived. Your awards go in a box in the garage. The unit you built gets reorganized by somebody who was not there when you built it, probably within four years of your departure.

What does not get reorganized is the agent who runs a track the way you showed him in 2018, and who is now showing somebody else, and who says "an old guy taught me this" without remembering your name.

That is the only compounding asset in this profession. Everything else is linear. You work an hour, you get an hour of output. Teaching is the one thing that multiplies, because the man you taught teaches two more and you are not involved in any of it.

Paul writes to Timothy with four generations in a single sentence. What you heard from me, commit to faithful men, who will teach others. Paul, Timothy, faithful men, others. He is describing a transmission chain and he is explicitly not describing a personal legacy, because by the third link nobody is thinking about Paul.

Notice the filter. Faithful men. Not the most talented. Not the ones who make you look good. Faithful, meaning the ones who will actually carry it and hand it on rather than collect it.

Most senior men in this work hold their knowledge tighter than they should. Some of it is time. Some of it is that the knowledge is the last thing that makes them necessary. That is understandable and it is still a

waste, because knowledge held is knowledge that dies on your retirement date.

THE DRILL

Pick one thing you know that is not written down anywhere and would leave with you. A way of reading ground. A way of talking to a family at the worst moment of their life. Write one page on it this week. Not a manual. One page. Then hand it to one man and make him teach it back to you.

God, most of what I know is going to walk out the door with me and I have been holding it because it makes me necessary. Show me the faithful man on my crew. Give me one page this week and the humility to hand it over. Amen.

ENTRY 33

The Long Career

Let us run with perseverance the race that is set before us.
HEBREWS 12:1

Twenty years is a distance event and almost nobody treats it like one.

Men come into this work and run the first four years the way you would run eight hundred meters. All out, every call, every detail, every collateral duty, volunteering for the schedule nobody wants because that is how you get seen. And it works, for a while. That guy gets noticed.

Then around year seven something changes and he cannot name it. He is still doing the hours and getting less out of them. He is irritable in a way that used to be occasional. He starts talking about the job in past tense while he is still in it.

That is not burnout arriving out of nowhere. That is a pacing failure that was set in motion in year two.

The verse says run with perseverance, and the word underneath it carries the sense of remaining under a load over time rather than pushing hard once. It is the language of endurance, not of effort. And it says the race that is set before us, which means the distance is not yours to choose. You do not get to decide it is a sprint because sprinting is what you are good at.

The first half of that same verse tells you to lay aside the weight. That is the pacing instruction. Not everything you can carry should be carried the whole distance.

For a working man this means something uncomfortable. Some of the collateral duties have to go. Some of the overtime is not financial anymore, it is identity, and you have to be honest about which. The man who is still standing at year twenty-two is almost never the man who was most impressive at year three.

THE DRILL

Write down everything you currently carry beyond your core duties. Collateral assignments, instructor billets, committees, the overtime you take by habit. Next to each one write why you took it and whether that reason still exists. Drop one before the next quarter. Not because you cannot handle it. Because the distance is twenty years.

God, I have been running a marathon at sprint pace and calling it commitment. Show me what to lay down. Let me be useful at year twenty and not just impressive at year four. Amen.

ENTRY 34

The Body Slows Down

Though our outward man is decaying, yet our inward man is renewed day by day.
2 CORINTHIANS 4:16

There is a day when you cannot do what you could do at twenty-five, and you find out about it in front of other people.

It is a hill you used to take without thinking. It is the young guy pulling away from you on a track and looking back to see where you are. It is your knee after a movement that would not have registered fifteen years ago. And the physical part is not what wrecks men. It is what the moment says about the arc.

Most men handle it in one of two bad ways. Some deny it, train through an injury that needed six weeks, and turn a manageable decline into a medical retirement. Others quit early and get soft at forty-four, decide the physical part of their identity is over, and lose ten years they could have had.

Paul does not do either. He says plainly that the outward man is wasting away, with no argument and no spin. That is a straight acknowledgment from a man who took more physical damage than most people reading this ever will. And then he sets the other thing beside it. The inward man is renewed day by day.

Two things are true at once. The decline is real, and it is not the whole account.

Practically, this is a transition in what you contribute, and the men who navigate it well start planning it around year twelve instead of discovering it at year nineteen. You stop being the man who runs the hill fastest and become the man who reads the ground, sets the plan, and keeps four young guys from doing something stupid on the far side of it.

That is not a demotion. It is the only path that leads anywhere except out.

THE DRILL

Name the specific physical thing you have lost, out loud, without arguing about it. Then name one thing you can do now that you could not do at twenty-five. Judgment, reading people, staying calm, knowing when not to go. Write both. Then adjust your training for the body you have rather than the one you are mourning.

God, I am slower and it happened while I was not paying attention. Keep me from wrecking myself proving otherwise and from quitting early out of pride. Renew the part of me that is not on the clock. Amen.

ENTRY 35

Who You Are Without the Badge

It is no longer I that live, but Christ lives in me.
GALATIANS 2:20

Take the credentials out of the answer and tell me who you are.

Most men in this work cannot do it. They get about eleven words in before the job appears, because for twenty years the honest answer to who are you has been the agency, the unit, and the years. That is not vanity. It is what happens when a thing consumes your hours, your body, your friendships, and your identity documents at the same time.

The bill for it arrives on a specific day. For some men it is retirement. For others it is a medical, or an administrative leave where the credentials go in an envelope and the man goes home at 1400 on a Tuesday with nothing to do and no name.

You have seen what that does. The guy who could not make it eighteen months past his retirement date. The one who kept showing up at the station for coffee for two years until somebody gently told him to stop.

Paul is writing about the most extreme version of this. He had a whole identity built on credentials, and he lists them elsewhere with some pride, and then he says the man who held them is dead and somebody else is living in this body now. His identity is no longer a set of accomplishments. It is a relationship that does not depend on being currently employed.

That is not a religious nicety. For a man in this profession it is load-bearing structural work, and it has to be done while the job is still going, because you cannot build an identity in the week after you lose one.

THE DRILL

Write your own introduction with no reference to the job, the agency, or any rank. Five sentences. It will be hard and it will be short and that is the finding. Keep the paper. Add one sentence a month until it is a real answer, because you will need it, and the date it gets needed is not yours to pick.

God, I have built the whole man on a job that ends on a date somebody else controls. Start building the part of me that is not the badge. Let me be somebody on the Tuesday after I turn it in. Amen.

ENTRY 36

Retirement Is a Deployment

The plans of the diligent surely lead to profit, and everyone who is hasty surely rushes to poverty.
PROVERBS 21:5

You would never move a team without a plan, and you are planning to leave this career with a date and a vague feeling.

Ask a man in year eighteen what his plan is. You will get a number and a mood. The number is the retirement date. The mood is some version of taking it easy for a while. That is not a plan, that is a departure time with nothing on the other end of it, and this profession is full of men who found that out the hard way.

Run it the way you would run any other movement. What is the objective. What is the timeline. What has to be in place before execution. What are the contingencies.

The specifics are yours to work out with people who know your actual numbers, and this book is not the place for that. A devotional has no business telling you what your finances should look like. But the discipline is the same discipline you already have, and you are simply not applying it here.

The proverb is about pace as much as it is about planning. The diligent plan and the hasty rush, and the distinction is time, not intelligence. A plan made at year twelve has room in it. A plan made at month three of terminal leave is a reaction.

There is a second piece that men skip entirely because it is harder to write on a calendar. What are you going to do on Tuesday. Not financially. Structurally. Twenty years of shift work built your entire week, your friendships, and your sense of being needed, and all three of those end on the same afternoon.

Men who do well at this have something already running before they walk out. A trade, a business, a role, a place they are expected to be.

THE DRILL

Put three dates on paper. The date you leave. A date two years before it, which is when the plan has to be in writing and reviewed by somebody qualified. And a date thirty days after you leave, with an actual commitment on it that somebody else is counting on you for. Then tell your wife all three.

God, I have a date and a feeling and I have called that a plan. Give me the diligence to write it down early and the humility to have somebody who knows the details look at it. Show me what I am walking toward, not just what I am walking out of. Amen.

ENTRY 37

The Man at the Funeral

Rejoice with those who rejoice. Weep with those who weep.
ROMANS 12:15

Go to the funeral.

You will have eleven reasons not to. It is a four hour drive each way, you are off that day, and you have slept about five hours in the last two. You did not know him well, his wife does not know you at all, and you will stand in a receiving line producing something that sounds hollow.

Go anyway. Put on the Class A uniform, stand where people can see you, and say the man's name out loud.

Here is what nobody tells young men about funerals. The words are not the point and they were never the point. Nothing you say to a widow at a graveside will help her that afternoon and she will not remember one sentence of it. What she will remember, with startling precision for the rest of her life, is who came. How many men in uniform were standing on that hill. Whether anybody drove four hours.

Attendance is the message. The rest is decoration.

A widow told a friend of mine, nine years after, that she counted the uniforms on the hill. She got to thirty-one. She could not tell him one thing anybody said at the reception, and she still knew the number.

Paul gives the instruction in two halves and the second half has no technique attached. Weep with those who weep. Not counsel them, not fix it, not explain what God is doing. Be present in it and let it land on you where the family can see.

Men in this line are conditioned against that. On a scene you have to stay outside the feeling so that your hands keep working, and that skill is real. But you carry it into a chapel, where the job is the exact opposite, and you stand at the back with the same flat face you wear on a fatality, and a

family reads it as cold.

The same rule runs the other direction and men skip that half even more. Show up to the retirement lunch. Show up to the kid's graduation. Rejoice with those who rejoice is the same command and it has fewer volunteers.

THE DRILL

Next one, go. Wear the uniform if it is appropriate. Find one family member, say the man's name and one specific true thing about him. "He taught me how to read a track in wet ground." Then stop talking and stand there for a full ten seconds. Do not fill the silence.

God, I skip the hard ones because I do not know what to say, and my absence says something worse than any wrong words would. Get me in the door and into the uniform. Let me say his name and then be quiet. Amen.

ENTRY 38

What Gets Written Down

> *Write the vision and make it plain on tablets, that he who runs may read it.*
> HABAKKUK 2:2

Almost everything you know is going to die with you and you have made peace with that without noticing.

There are men who have worked twenty-four years in this profession and never written down one page of what they learned. Not because they are selfish. Because nobody ever told them that the stuff in their head qualifies as knowledge. It feels like experience, which feels like something you either have or do not, rather than something that can be transferred.

It can be transferred. That is the whole basis of doctrine. Somebody sat down and made a thing explicit that had been implicit for a generation, and then it stopped dying every time a senior man retired.

Look at the instruction. Write it, make it plain, so that a man running can read it. That is a usability standard and it is three thousand years old. Plain enough to be read at speed by somebody in motion. Not a thesis. Not an academic product. Something a man can use while he is moving.

That should take the pressure off. You are not being asked to write a book. You are being asked to make one thing plain.

Start with the thing you correct most often. Every senior man has one. The same mistake, made by every new guy, that you have explained out loud about sixty times. That repetition is the tell. Anything you have explained sixty times is doctrine that has not been written down yet.

One page. Written the way you would say it. Then hand it to the next man who makes the mistake and see if the page does the work instead of you.

THE DRILL

Pick the correction you give most often. Write it on one page tonight, in your own voice, in four parts. What goes wrong. Why it goes wrong. What to do instead. How you know it worked. Give it to one man this week and watch where he gets confused, because that is where the page needs fixing.

God, I have been carrying things in my head that other men need and I have never written one page of it down. Give me an hour tonight and one clear thing to make plain. Let it be usable by a man in a hurry. Amen.

ENTRY 39

Handing Off the Post

Take Joshua the son of Nun, a man in whom is the Spirit, and lay your hand on him.
NUMBERS 27:18

You can tell everything about a man by how he does a relief briefing.

The bad version takes nine seconds. He is already walking. "Nothing going on, radio is acting up, see you." And the man coming on now has to rebuild the entire picture from scratch, in the dark, and will find out about the thing that matters at the worst possible time.

The good version takes four minutes and the man relieving you can work off it immediately. What happened. What is still open. What you were worried about that never developed. What the equipment is doing. Where the gaps are. Who to call.

Nobody grades the handoff. That is exactly why it tells you who somebody is.

Moses is at the end of the largest leadership assignment in the Old Testament, and he is not going to see the objective completed. He knows it. What he asks for is not an extension. He asks God to appoint a man over the people so they will not be like sheep without a shepherd, and then he lays hands on Joshua publicly so that everybody sees the authority transfer.

He does the handoff. In front of people. With no ambiguity about who is in charge afterward.

Most men do the opposite. They hold on. They stay involved after they have left, they take calls they should not take, they let the new man run a unit with the previous man's shadow in every room. That is not loyalty to the mission. It is difficulty letting go, and it costs the new man about two years.

Every post you hold is temporary. The only question is whether you hand it off clean.

THE DRILL

Do your next relief briefing properly, even if the guy relieving you does not want it. Four minutes. Open items, what worried you, equipment status, who to call. Then go home and do not call to check on it. The second half is the hard half.

God, I hand things off badly because letting go feels like not caring. Teach me to brief clean, name the man, and then actually leave. Let the next one be better than I was without needing me in the room. Amen.

ENTRY 40

Standing Down

I have fought the good fight. I have finished the course. I have kept the faith.
2 TIMOTHY 4:7

One day you will put this down.

It will be a specific date, probably on a form. You will turn in credentials, a weapon, a vehicle, and a set of keys, and somebody twenty-six years old will process it in about eleven minutes and then ask if you need anything else.

Then you will walk out to the parking lot for the last time as a man who does this work, and you will sit in your own truck, and it will be very quiet.

What you say in that truck was decided years before, by how you worked.

Paul writes that sentence from a cell, near the end, with no organizational support and no ceremony coming. He gives three items and they are worth noticing individually. I fought the good fight, which is about the quality of the contest and not the outcome. I finished the course, which is about distance, and finishing is the whole claim. I kept the faith, which is about what he protected on the way through.

Not one of the three is a result. No numbers. No rank. No list of what got accomplished. Fought well, went the distance, held on to the thing that mattered.

That is available to you regardless of how the career actually goes. The board is not in your control. The assignment you wanted is not in your control. Your body is only partly in your control. Those three items are entirely yours.

And this is the reason for forty days of anything. Not so you become a

spiritual man in forty days. So that on the day you sit in that truck, prayer is not a foreign object you have to go find under pressure. It is a position you have held so many times that you drop into it without deciding to.

THE DRILL

Write the sentence you want to be able to say honestly in that parking lot. One sentence, no rank in it, no accomplishments. Then look at this week and name one specific thing you are doing that makes the sentence more true, and one that makes it less. Change the second one. That is the whole practice, and you start it today, not at the end.

God, I am going to put this down one day and sit in a quiet truck with whatever I built. Let me be able to say that I fought well, went the distance, and held on to you. Start that work now, while I still have shifts left. Amen.

L A S T T H I N G

Forty days does not make you a holy man. It makes you a man who has prayed forty times more than he did last month, which is the only measurable thing any of this was ever going to produce.

Start it again. The entries read differently in February than they did in November, because you are not the same man and the job did not stay the same either.

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ONE ASK

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